

After Action Review of UNDP's Response to the Nepal Earthquakes in 2015

November 2016

Abbreviations

AAR	After Action Review
BCP	Business Continuity Planning
BMS	Bureau of Management Services
BPPS	Bureau for Policy and Programme Support
BRH	Bangkok Regional Hub
CB	Crisis Board
CMST	Crisis Management Support Team
CO	Country Office
CPR TTF	Crisis Prevention & Recovery Thematic Trust Fund
CRU	Crisis Response Unit
DCD	Deputy Country Director
DFAT	Department of Foreign Aid and Trade (Government of Australia)
DP	Development Partners
EDRCR	Emergency Development Responses for Crisis and Recovery
ER	Early Recovery
FA	Flash Appeal
FGD	Focus Group Discussion
FTP	Fast Track Procedures
GoN	Government of Nepal
HC	Humanitarian Coordinator
HQ	Headquarters
IASC	Inter-Agency Standing Committee
IOM	International Organization for Migration
IR	Inception Report
KII	Key Informant Interview
LGCDP	Local Government Capacity Development Programme
MEDEP	Microenterprise Development Programme
MoFALD	Ministry of Federal Affairs and Local Development
MOUD	Ministry of Urban Development
NGO	Non-Governmental Organization
NPC	National Planning Commission
NY	New York (UNDP HQ)
PDNA	Post Disaster Needs Assessment
PDRF	Post Disaster Recovery Framework
RC	Resident Coordinator
RBAP	Regional Bureau for Asia-Pacific
SOP	Standard Operating Procedures
TOR	Terms of Reference
UNCT	United Nations Country Team
UNDP	United Nations Development Programme
UNV	United Nations Volunteers
VDC	Village Development Council

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Summary of Lessons from the After Action Review

Corporate Crisis Response Mechanism

1. The Crisis Board (CB) was able to mobilize a whole-of-UNDP rapid response to the earthquake. The role of Crisis Management Support Team (CMST) was crucial in success of the CB and ensuring that its decisions were followed up at various ends.
2. The SURGE plan needs to take into account clear analysis of interventions by other key actors, government priorities and donor environment in the country, besides the needs of affected communities.
3. SURGE briefing and debriefing before and after deployment is an important means to ensure that all deployed are fairly self-sufficient without much assistance from the CO.
4. SURGE team members, once deployed, need to agree their leave plans with the CO, especially when they are deployed for very short periods (4-6 weeks).

Programmatic Response

5. While focusing on getting the early response going, a clear articulation of how UNDP would work with the Government, other UN agencies, clusters and development partners (DP) on developing a short- and long-term recovery strategy with a long-term vision is required in the first few weeks.
6. In all phases of the disaster response and particularly during and after a Post-Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA), UNDP needs to ensure that it has good capacity to develop a well-articulated strategy and vision that articulates how it envisages supporting the GoN in re-establishing government functions and work with the latter in developing a short term and long-term recovery strategy.
7. Dialogue with development partners and governments on financing mechanisms for early recovery and reconstruction needs to start immediately after a disaster and continue during and after PDNA.
8. UNDP's response should be determined by how it positions itself early on in support of the government's overall recovery planning and strategy, and how it engages with various development partners and provides leadership to the early recovery cluster.
9. Careful analysis is needed where UNDP can add significant value according to its niche and competence. While UNDP needs to pay attention to early recovery interventions (such as debris clearance), this should not be allowed to take attention away from supporting the government in developing an overall strategy. It's also important to contextualize early recovery interventions and combine different activities, such as debris clearance, on the one hand, and ensuring rehabilitation of functioning public infrastructure and services in the immediate aftermath of a major earthquake, on the other.
10. Promoting innovations and private sector engagement (with UNDP and governments) as a key focus of UNDP in disaster response could position it distinctly from other humanitarian agencies.

11. UNDP's response works best when it is linked to and builds on its ongoing programmes and competence.

Operational Response

12. With staff changes, training, orientation and updating of preparedness/business continuity plan (BCP) need to be undertaken every six months.
13. Although Fast Track Procedure (FTP) was activated, the CO had to revert back to HQ for approvals frequently on recruitment. Additionally, lack of orientation of CO staff in implementing FTP sometimes caused delays.
14. If staff are seriously affected by a disaster, country offices (CO) need to have discretion to allocate small funds to cover essential expenses for providing basic survival assistance to national staff.

Inter-Agency Coordination

15. UNDP needs to ensure that it 'firewalls' early recovery cluster role from its own early recovery interventions in future.
16. UNDP needs to develop, working with local and national institutions (and UN Capital Development Fund), specialized expertise in providing support (inclusive financial infrastructure, market and local economy assessments, cash transfer technology, transparency and assurance mechanisms etc.) to cash-based response which is increasingly expanding in post-disaster response.
17. Advocacy needed at IASC level to agree transition mechanism to coordinate recovery after departure of OCHA, especially where national capacity to coordinate international response is weak.

Resource Mobilization

18. Clear articulation of a medium- and long- term vision is needed to engage with donors early on in the response. Towards this end, deployment of senior communication staff capable of working with programme team to develop clear communication messages for donors is crucial.
19. UNDP should finalize a clear offer to the private sector in the future to pursue and receive support and funding from the private sector in crisis contexts.

Introduction

21. On 25 April 2015, a devastating earthquake hit Nepal causing severe destruction of lives and property in 14 of the country's 75 districts. This was followed by another severe earthquake on 12 May 2015 which further worsened the humanitarian situation. The two earthquakes affected over 5 million people and the death toll was 8,702.¹ The earthquakes destroyed 498,852 houses and 2,656 government buildings, besides partially damaging another 256,697 private houses and 3,622 government buildings. Additionally, roads, bridges, water supplies, schools, hospitals in the main cities and in rural areas across more than two-third of Nepal's 75 districts suffered severe damages.²

22. The humanitarian consequences from the earthquake triggered a large-scale international humanitarian response under the leadership of the Government of Nepal (GoN). The international humanitarian cluster system was formally activated immediately after the first earthquake by the Emergency Relief Coordinator (ERC) of the United Nations.

Background

23. The United Nations Development Programme (UNDP), which has an on-going multi-sectoral development programme in the country, mobilized in a substantive way to respond to the crisis. UNDP's response was geared toward developing an integrated programmatic and operational plan that responded to both the immediate needs and the imperative of preparing the ground for long-term recovery from the crisis. This was intended to be achieved by launching an early recovery response as well as providing leadership to the early recovery (ER) cluster and developing a 'core resilience-based approach to recovery'.³ When the earthquakes struck, UNDP at the corporate level had just revised its crisis response strategy that included programme, operations, communications, enhanced deployment mechanisms, and resource mobilization, among others. The crisis response strategy, with a global scope, concretely expresses UNDP's commitment to step up its capacity to be prepared and capable of responding to a crisis in a predictable manner. The Nepal crisis was one of the first and very initial testing ground⁴ for the revised crisis response strategy.

24. A few months preceding the earthquake, UNDP had undergone a significant restructuring, with the Crisis Response Unit (CRU) emerging as a new structure to coordinate UNDP's corporate response and improve the organization's ability to mount a quick response to crisis. In line with corporate procedures corresponding to this magnitude of crisis,⁵ UNDP decided to undertake an after action review (AAR) to serve as an internal learning exercise to gain useful insights into how an organization-wide strategy can support the UNDP country office (CO) and key partners in the immediate aftermath of a disaster. The objective of AAR was to examine the performance of UNDP with respect to response to the earthquakes in Nepal in first six months, and highlight lessons

¹ As of 3 June 2015, source: <http://data.unhcr.org/nepal>. Over 200 people were missing at the time.

² Post Disaster Recovery Framework, Government of Nepal, 2016

³ Terms of Reference, After Action Review for Crisis Response to Earthquakes in Nepal, UNDP, 2015.

⁴ The other – prior to Nepal earthquake – was the tropical cyclone Pam in the Pacific

⁵ Nepal earthquake was classified as L2 emergency as per UNDP's crisis response SOP. UNDP has 3 levels of crises depending on several factors: (i) L1 – where the CO has capacity to manage the response with some ad hoc support from HQ; (ii) L2 – where the CO can manage the response only with substantial day-to-day support from the HQ/RBAP; and (iii) L3 – corporate emergencies which require the attention of the entire organization due to the scale, complexity, resource requirements and interagency/international dimensions of a crisis.

learned that would help strengthen functioning, performance and efficiency of UNDP's disaster response in future. The focus of the AAR was on the application/deployment of tools, processes and resources in the immediate crisis response period governed by a Crisis Board (which was dissolved on 13 October 2015), and draw forward-looking recommendations for corporate crisis preparedness and response tools in view of their application to future crisis response situations.

25. The AAR was carried out by an independent consultant in September 2016. At the time of this AAR, the CO was also about to undertake its own lessons learning exercise with focus on programmatic issues covering the entire response so far. In a way, the two processes and outcomes draw on each other: this AAR focused on the immediate response period (first six months) while the CO lessons learned exercise has a wider scope and covers the entire period so far. The CO lessons learned exercise serves as an annex to this AAR. The detailed methodology used for the AAR is elaborated in the inception report attached as in the annex. In brief, the key methods used were:

- Desk review of key documents;
- Key informant interviews and focus group discussions with:
 - a. UNDP headquarters staff in New York (NY), the Bangkok Regional Hub (BRH)
 - b. UNDP Nepal staff;
 - c. UN Country Team (UNCT), Resident Coordinator and staff;
 - d. Government of Nepal – key officials who acted as focal points for UNDP on clusters and recovery;
 - e. Selected NGOs active in the early recovery/recovery programmes in Nepal;
 - f. Key donor agencies funding UNDP's programme in Nepal;
- Participation in a CO AAR workshop where CO staff shared their experiences and lessons.

26. Altogether, 40 individuals were interviewed (details Annex 3) – the breakdown of different stakeholder groups is provided below:

a. UNDP Headquarters (NY and BRH)	14
b. UNDP Nepal	15
c. UNCT staff	3
d. Government of Nepal representatives	2
e. NGO representatives in Nepal	3
f. Donor representatives funding UNDP (Nepal-based)	3

27. In line with the terms of reference, the AAR focused on the following five areas to draw lessons from the Nepal response:

- Crisis response mechanism
- Programmatic response
- Operational response
- Inter-agency coordination
- Resource mobilization

Timeline of UNDP's Response

25-Apr-15	Gorkha earthquake
27-Apr-15	ER cluster initiated
27-Apr-15	First CB meeting (26-Apr, NY)
29-Apr-15	Flash Appeal launch (USD 415 million)
30-Apr-15	UNDP SURGE team starts to arrive
1-May-15	First early recovery cluster meeting
9-May-15	SURGE planning team leaves Nepal
12-May-15	2 nd earthquake
12-May-15	UNDP SURGE Plan produced (USD 175 million)
15-May-15	PDNA process starts
29-May-15	Revised Flash Appeal launched (USD 422 million)
25-Jun-15	PDNA launch and donor conference
13-Aug-15	NRA CEO appointed
25-Aug-15	UNDP Nepal recovery strategy draft
30-Sep-15	Humanitarian Phase close
1-Oct-15	ER cluster final report
11-Oct-15	Change of Government
1-Nov-15	Livelihood Assessment Report
24-Nov-15	Sindupalchowk Livelihood WG
28-Nov-15	Gorkha Review of Humanitarian Response and Strategic Planning for Recovery
1-Dec-15	HCT After Action Review
4-Dec-15	ER Cluster close

Process and Limitations of the After Action Review

28. This AAR was carried out almost a year after the immediate crisis response period – which is the focus of this AAR – came to an end. Though care has been taken to ensure that findings are triangulated from several sources, people's perceptions and recollection of events of that period may be coloured by what has transpired in the subsequent period, as it is natural for key informants to give primacy to their most recent experiences.

29. As part of lessons learning and moving forward, UNDP ought to carry out AARs periodically during the first six months after a crisis strikes to take stock and derive lessons that can serve as course correctors and sharpen the strategic thrust for the recovery programme. AARs will be more valuable for shaping the response if undertaken on time.

Key Findings and Lessons

Corporate Crisis Response Mechanism

Findings

30. Immediately after the earthquake, UNDP moved quite fast to take a few major decisions which helped shape the scope and direction of its response:

- a. Working with CRU, the Resident/Humanitarian Coordinator (RC/HC) and Regional Bureau for Asia Pacific (RBAP) decided that Nepal crisis would be dealt as a L2 response,⁶ meaning thereby that CO will manage the response with expanded support and mobilization from New York (NY) and Bangkok Regional Hub (BRH), coordinated through a Crisis Board (CB) chaired by the Deputy Director of RBAP. This was a significant decision and was in line with how other agencies – through the leadership of Inter Agency Standing Committee (IASC) - were dealing with the disaster.
- b. The first CB meeting was convened within less than 48 hours of the earthquake and Fast Track Procedures (FTP) to facilitate speedy response to the crisis was activated.
- c. Decision to deploy two early recovery cluster coordinators and one communications specialist as first responders, and offer secondment of a recovery adviser to the Resident Coordinator's Office (RCO) – this offer was however not accepted by the RC/HC on the ground that the RCO already had adequate capacity.
- d. By day 4, a full complement of SURGE planning team with senior people knowledgeable about the country was put in place for deployment.
- e. Immediate release of funds from TRAC 3 and Crisis Prevention and Recovery Thematic Trust Fund (CPR TTF), in addition to reprogrammed resources at the CO level.
- f. A SURGE plan for three to six months was produced fairly rapidly within 2 weeks of the earthquake by the SURGE team deployed between 30 April and 9 May 2015.

31. UNDP had Standard Operating Procedures (SOPs) for Immediate Crisis Response. At the time of the earthquake, the SOPs were under revision. The revision was meant to further clarify specific roles and responsibilities of UNDP after the 2014 restructuring, including division of labour between headquarters, the Regional Hubs and the COs, level of authority for allocation of funds, deployment of first responders and clearly distinguish between the support to be provided in different levels of response (L1, L2, L3). The CB took a decision to deploy a team of first responders from the BRH, with staff who had good knowledge of the country.

32. The CB met at least 8 times during the period 26/27 April and 9 June 2015, with meetings taking place every 3-5 days in the first three weeks. **Staff interviewed felt that in general the CB meetings had the right level of participation and were well chaired, with focus on both decision-making and information sharing.** However, sometimes the CB meetings veered more to meeting the information needs of various parts of the HQ, some of which could have been dealt with on a bi-lateral basis. Each meeting of the CB was preceded by meetings of Crisis Management Support

⁶ UNDP categorizes crises at three levels (L1, L2, L3) depending on a combination of factors namely, scale of disaster, urgency, capacity, complexity and reputational risk and this determines how support will be mobilized and response managed at CO, region and HQ level.

Team (CMST) involving Deputy Country Director (Programme) from the CO and specialists from all relevant UNDP Bureaus (both NY and Bangkok-based) which helped prepare the agenda for CBs. There are generic terms of reference for the CMST and the latter ensured at technical level that support from various bureaus in NY and BRH was well coordinated, and that CB decisions were acted upon in a timely manner.

33. The CB process, along with the CMST meetings, helped streamline support from the Bureau of Management Services (BMS), Bureau for Policy and Programme Support (BPPS) and other departments in NY. On 27 April 2015, the BPPS and CRU approved an amount USD 160,000 from TRAC 1.1.3 Cat. II (for coordination and assessment),⁷ and a month later (27 May 2015), BPPS approved another USD 1 million for a recovery programming from the CPR TTF. At the CO level, working with development partners, rapid decisions were taken to release unspent funds from key projects (Local Government Capacity Development Programme) to fast-track response.

34. UNDP produced a SURGE plan⁸ within two weeks of the disaster – the plan estimated a requirement of USD 175 million for UNDP over a three-year period. A number of internal stakeholders⁹ observed that **it was not grounded on reality and did not take into account funding environment in the country and UNDP's positioning vis-à-vis the humanitarian and development institutions in the country. With hindsight, many felt that the plan had very little by way of analysis of other stakeholders' response, donor context in the country and government's focus and capacity.** The SURGE plan did identify key priorities¹⁰ but only superficially included certain key factors in its analysis – donor environment and appetite,¹¹ UNDP's credibility with donors,¹² and UNDP's distinctive competence. This was mainly due to the fact that in its rush to launch its response, the plan came too early in the response when immediate relief was still the overriding focus of all agencies.

35. **The CO noted that the CB process worked smoothly and communication with CRU and RBAP was seamless in supporting early response.** Some participants in CB felt that it was sometimes 'over-engineered' to get participation of as many people as were interested, rather than ensuring a need-to-involve basis. A large participation from the NY end may have drowned the voices of the regional hub who were probably better aware of the ground situation.

36. The CB endorsed candidates for SURGE deployment. UNDP now has over 400 staff on its SURGE roster, of which about 250 were trained in crisis response by UNDP. Besides this, UNDP has

⁷ TRAC 3 allocations were managed by BPPS and CRU jointly as an interim measure in early 2015 (signed by BPPS). Now these are fully managed by CRU only.

⁸ The main purpose of the SURGE plan is to identify what additional capacities (i.e. deployments) are needed, by sketching out the CO's envisaged response. While it may have been overly ambitious, it's only the first sketch of the CO's Recovery Programme Framework (which was elaborated by the CO later in the response).

⁹ The CO was also concerned about the methodology for arriving at such an ambitious surge Plan immediately after the disaster when data on damage and assessments were not available yet.

¹⁰ It outlined three pillars of intervention: 1) livelihoods restored and economic recovery ensured (in the short term); 2) local governance function restored for effective public services/housing (in the medium term); and 3) national capacities strengthened for recovery planning and DRR –building back better (over the longer term).

¹¹ This concern was also raised in the 5th CB meeting (Source: Minutes of UNDP 5th Crisis Board Meeting on Nepal Response to Earthquake, UNDP, 13 May 2015)

¹² Prior to the earthquake, during 2013-14, UNDP programme in Nepal have had some bad reviews (for example: mid-term review of CDRMP) and audit which donors were concerned about that led key donors to exercise 'extreme caution' in dealing with funding proposals from UNDP Nepal. The environment, as reported by donors, is gradually changing as they have noted several improvements over the past two years.

a roster of consultants and six stand-by partners who provide pro bono services. Before every deployment, a clear TOR was developed by the CO and agreed with the CRU. Each SURGE team member underwent systematic briefing and debriefing before and after deployment and, in the early weeks, all those deployed were fairly self-sufficient in that they could hit the ground running without much assistance from the CO. The CO together with the RCO developed a briefing package and orientation on country context for all arriving SURGE deployments. **At the CO end, the DCD (Programme) was the SURGE focal point working closely with CRU, and this worked well as the former had good insights into CO capacity and priorities.** As the SURGE deployment was at the request of the CO and was made at a pace the latter could manage, scaling up and scaling back did not cause any disruptions.

37. Feedback from internal stakeholders indicate that the SURGE team and the CO worked well together as most of those deployed in the early weeks have had either direct experience of working in Nepal or the region. The interaction and engagement between the SURGE team and the CO went smoothly, with joint thinking and planning. **Key informants felt that UNDP did get the overall balance of deployment right in terms of mix of people with national, regional and international experience.** Several SURGE team members, however, went on leave whilst being on SURGE for short-time (2-3 months), something which the CO was initially unaware of, though this was agreed by individuals with the CRU before their deployment.

Lessons

- Preparatory work by the CMST was critical to successful conduct of CB meetings and this should be standardized in all response and participation in CB should be based on an individual's ability to add substantive value to the discussions and ensure follow through of CB decisions.
- The SURGE planning needs to take into account clear analysis of interventions by other key actors, government priorities and donor environment in the country, besides the needs of affected communities.
- SURGE deployments ensured that each deployed staff underwent systematic briefing and debriefing before and after deployment. In the early weeks, all those deployed were fairly self-sufficient in that they could hit the ground running without much assistance from the CO.
- Once deployed, staff need to agree their holiday/leave plans with the CO, as stipulated in the SOP. However, this probably needs reinforcing and clearly communicating to the deployed staff.

Programmatic Response

Findings

38. The SOP followed during the response helped clarify internal division of labour between different parts of the organization and ensured that the entire organization mobilized at different levels to support the response and also ensured a rapid SURGE team deployment. The CB focused on early response and operational issues and to this end, according to all key informants and focus groups, it was very effective. However, by its very nature of being preoccupied with 'here and

now' situation, it could not dwell on strategic issues like developing some of the medium to long term vision for recovery, supporting the government in recovery planning and coordination, and positioning UNDP vis-à-vis other major players in its support to an overall national recovery strategy. Interviews with internal stakeholders indicated that preoccupation with UNDP's own programme interventions might have deflected attention away from the need for more strategic thinking in shaping the overall response in early phase. **What was missing in the first few months was a clear articulation of how UNDP would support the GoN in developing an overall recovery strategy and engage with other UN agencies, clusters and development partners (DP) projecting a long-term vision.** The SURGE Plan did have an articulation of UNDP's strategy, but it was prepared too soon, when the humanitarian phase was still in progress and could not therefore project much beyond the immediate relief phase.

39. UNDP invested heavily in the Post-Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA) – as evidenced in the fact that UNDP mobilized over 15 international experts and CO staff for this exercise – and its role in the process is widely acknowledged by all stakeholders. Almost all stakeholders were unanimous in their opinion that **the expertise provided by UNDP was critical for producing a high quality PDNA, and the strong emphasis on vulnerability, gender and social inclusion the PDNA laid came mainly from UNDP.** An examination of CB minutes¹³ shows that the former was conscious of this and noted that drawing lessons from Pakistan flood experience, PDNA needed to avoid having a narrow focus on infrastructure alone and incorporate gender, disaster risk reduction and softer issues such as inclusion, livelihood and governance. Besides bringing in a number of experts, UNDP supported the PDNA secretariat and worked closely with the National Planning Commission (NPC).

40. However, after the PDNA was completed, UNDP took a backseat and did not capitalize on it by taking a lead in engaging with development partners and GoN on a long-term strategy. The inability to articulate a clear vision came up in several discussions with internal and external stakeholders – **that UNDP was seen to be trying to compete for 'humanitarian space' while its response should be determined by how it positions itself in support of the government's overall recovery planning and strategy, and how it engages with various development partners.** Interviews with external stakeholders – NGOs and donors, in particular – suggest that, except for support on the PDNA, UNDP only played a peripheral role like many others in engaging with the government and development partners on development of an overall strategy. With hindsight, the CO attributes this gap to absence of a Senior Recovery Specialist Advisor – beyond the PDNA period – tasked with advising the UNDP CO team. The ER Cluster Coordinator was dedicated to cluster coordination and the Senior Recovery Advisor's role was limited to the PDNA exercise. UNDP did deploy recovery coordinators on short missions but they had limitations in providing continuous and coherent support.

41. Some of this lack of follow-up initiative could be attributed to political uncertainty surrounding the constitutional amendment and the blockade at the country's border with India, which created a political crisis and put the entire government machinery in a state of limbo for months in the latter half of 2015. All these delayed setting up of the National Reconstruction Authority (NRA) by about 8-9 months. Besides, the fact that the relationship between traditional donors and the GoN was often unpredictable – a very successful pledging conference in June 2015 notwithstanding – also contributed to uncertainties over long term recovery financing.

¹³ Minutes of UNDP 7th Crisis Board Meeting on Nepal Response to Earthquake, UNDP, 29 May 2015

42. It is reported that the CO received a call from NY even before the arrival of the SURGE team to suggest that debris management should be a priority and the SURGE team should develop a clear programme for this. The SURGE team presented the plan to the CO on 12 May 2015 where the idea of prioritizing private buildings for debris management using cash-for-work approach was outlined. The plan was in line with UNDP's corporate crisis response package (still under development at the time of the earthquake) and focused on: (a) livelihood restoration and economic recovery; (b) restoration of local governance function for effective public services/housing; and (c) strengthening national capacity for recovery planning and disaster risk reduction. The CO adopted the proposal of the SURGE planning team as it built on several components of the existing country programme that it was undertaking in partnership with GoN, namely:¹⁴

- Local Governance and Community Development Programme
- Micro-enterprise Development Programme (MEDEP)
- Comprehensive Disaster Risk Management Programme (CDRMP)
- Livelihood Recovery for Peace (LRP)
- Strengthening Rule of Law and Human Rights (ROLHR)

43. UNDP undertook demolition and debris removal of private houses in 3 village development committees (VDC, or sub-districts) of one district, through linking this with cash-for-work for affected families. This was too small a scale (3,468 houses)¹⁵ to make any significant difference in the overall national response where nearly half a million houses were totally destroyed, although for the households targeted in remote areas, UNDP's assistance was highly valuable. Moreover, this raised expectation in other districts, and the GoN at the central level did not appreciate this approach, though these may have been agreed at local levels with district and VDC authorities in areas which UNDP targeted. Several donors were critical of the approach taken by UNDP as this was very costly (one UNDP source mentioned a figure of approximately USD 1,000 for each house). The choice to go for private buildings was made at that time considering the need of some of the most-affected households and the understanding that IOM was focusing on public buildings. Subsequently, UNDP changed its focus from private houses to debris clearance for public building (offices, schools, VDC buildings) by October-November 2015 and temporary rehabilitation of local government offices.¹⁶ UNDP's support for rehabilitation of local governance structures was slow. Several other agencies (at least two NGOs were named) were much faster in their response on this. **If UNDP had done debris management in relation to public buildings right from the start, public services could have been restored earlier.**

44. While debris management was a critical issue and UNDP rightly picked this up early on for its focus, most internal and external stakeholders interviewed during the AAR strongly criticized UNDP's approach and suggested that UNDP should have instead, or additionally, focused primarily on public buildings in urban and peri-urban centres to get the government offices re-established quickly enough. For this, it would have been necessary to hire private contractors and heavy equipment suppliers from neighbouring countries which UNDP could have done. However, as mentioned earlier, UNDP agreed with the International Organization for Migration (IOM) that the former would focus on private houses while the latter work in urban areas. IOM and WFP (cash

¹⁴ UNDP. UNDP SURGE Plan Response to Nepal Earthquake of April 2015, May to October 2015

¹⁵ UNDP Nepal Annual Report, UNDP 2015

¹⁶ FGD with district coordinators indicated that in two districts, UNDP started working on prefabricated public building after about 2 months, but elsewhere these were done in October-November.

for work) did some of the work related to demolition of unsafe public building and their debris clearance, though on a very small scale. UNDP had hired or deployed six international¹⁷ and 90 local UN Volunteers (UNV) engineers¹⁸ to assist with demolition and debris clearing of private houses. Government stakeholders opined that if this huge resource was made available to the government, they could have carried out damage assessment of public buildings in districts and municipalities much faster to pave the ground for rehabilitation of these offices.

45. According to a significant majority of external and internal key informants, UNDP should have supported the GoN and local governments in affected areas with staff/experts to assist in rapid assessments and coordination in a significant way and assisted local authorities in setting up tents and temporary offices right from the start – something UNDP did after 4-6 months. Debris management was certainly a critical need, but the question is whether UNDP focused on the right debris. Although demolition of damaged private houses and clearing of the rubbles in affected communities were highly useful for the beneficiaries, UNDP's capacity is not geared toward these to deliver on a significant scale, given the relative scale of need. Several UNDP stakeholders also suggested that getting directly operational in debris management meant that senior staff had to spend an awful amount of time on administrative and operations aspects of the interventions at the cost of providing strategic direction and leadership. **The perception that UNDP focused on direct delivery of activities like debris clearing for private houses and cash for work to increase its visibility like other humanitarian agencies also arose from a lack of clear communication strategy articulating how UNDP envisaged supporting the GoN in re-establishing government functions and worked with the latter in developing a short- and long-term strategy.**

46. On the positive side of debris interventions, UNDP provided training to rural house owners in safe demolition. It developed guidelines and radio campaigns to train people in safe demolition which were – and are still being - used by many agencies. The radio programme had a wide coverage. Besides this, an innovation in the response was development of debris management app through Microsoft support. This app was immensely helpful in monitoring volume of work and tracking payments made for cash for work during debris removal. Another innovative approach was the use of UNV mechanism through which UNDP recruited 90 local engineers to support debris management work. The UNV engineers served as supervisors of cash-for-work brigades, providing technical instructions to workers and making important daily decisions on-site, in coordination with the UNDP international experts on demolition. The UN volunteers were the main users of the Microsoft debris management application, collecting data on the ground and transmitting these to UNDP.

47. Livelihoods interventions was another element of the response had UNDP had taken a strong lead on, as this built on its existing Micro-Enterprise Development Programme (MEDEP) that UNDP had been implementing since 2013 and which the CO scaled up rapidly after the earthquake. At least in seven of the affected districts, most of the entrepreneurs lost much of their assets. After a rapid assessment,¹⁹ UNDP mobilized additional funds through a supplementary

¹⁷ At least six of the SURGE deployments in the first couple of months after the earthquake were related to debris management.

¹⁸ Subsequently (in the post-surge period), UNDP is reported to have hired 577 skilled engineers over the year for damage assessment and trained 673 masons in seismic resistant construction practices (Source: Post-Earthquake and Early Recovery Interventions by UNDP Nepal, May 2015-April 2016, UNDP, 2016)

¹⁹ Through the Rapid Enterprise and Livelihoods Recovery Project (RELRP), UNDP set up helpdesks in seven of the 15 most-affected districts and collected data on losses and supported entrepreneurs in linking up with organizations providing relief (Source: Changing the Narrative – Building Back Better in Nepal, RELRP Project document, UNDP Nepal, 2015)

grant from DFAT (USD 5.4 million²⁰) in May 2015 for rehabilitation of the affected entrepreneurs. Help-desks were set up in these 7 districts immediately after the earthquake. It is reported that UNDP was able to assist and rehabilitate over 10,000 micro-entrepreneurs who had lost their assets to the earthquake.

48. The UNDP Regional Director for Asia-Pacific visited Nepal after the PDNA. Around the same time, the CO took strategic decisions regarding a shift from debris removal for private houses to public infrastructure and temporary rehabilitation public buildings. This started giving UNDP better space to engage with the GoN on development of a national recovery framework. UNDP supported district authorities in preparing district recovery plans and linking these to their normal district development plans. UNDP also assisted the MoFALD in developing guidelines for district recovery plans.

49. Government stakeholders interviewed for the AAR observed that they had little capacity to coordinate or articulate clear strategy for dialogue with DPs and other international agencies. This is one area where support from UNDP and other international agencies early on would have been helpful. This was foreseen in the SURGE Plan but the space to engage on donor coordination was limited as the GoN was giving out conflicting signals, which delayed deployment of the aid management SURGE advisor significantly. UNDP did subsequently get to work with the GoN during later part of the year when it played a key role in setting up and supporting the National Reconstruction Authority (NRA) in December 2015. One reason why a long-term recovery strategy following the PDNA took several months to develop was the fact that political landscape in the country was in a state of turmoil after the promulgation of the new Constitution and the country having to deal with a blockade on the country's border. It is only in the first half of 2016 that a Post-Disaster Recovery Framework (PDRF) was drawn up. UNDP along with the World Bank (WB) and other development partners provided technical assistance to the NRA for preparing a 5-year PDRF which was launched in May 2016. The PDRF estimated a total financing need of USD 8.37 billion, of which the GoN has already mobilized USD 1.9 billion.²¹

Lessons

- UNDP succeeded in mobilizing a whole-of-UNDP response and a substantial number of experts for its early response, but could have done more to develop and communicate a clear vision articulating how UNDP would work with all stakeholders towards medium and long-term recovery.
- In all phases of the disaster response and particularly during and after a Post-Disaster Needs Assessment (PDNA), UNDP needs to ensure that it has good capacity to develop a well-articulated strategy and vision, and communicate these with development partners and government agencies. Right from the start, UNDP's clear communication strategy should articulate how it envisages supporting the GoN in re-establishing government functions and work with the latter in developing a short term and long-term recovery strategy.
- Dialogue with DPs and governments on financing mechanisms for early recovery and reconstruction needs to start immediately after a disaster and continue during and after PDNA.

²⁰ Out of a total budget of USD 9.6 million.

²¹ Supporting Nepal in Building Back Better – UNDP Strategy for Earthquake Recovery Assistance, UNDP, May 2016

- UNDP's response should be determined by how it positions itself early on in support of the government's overall recovery planning and strategy, and how it engages with various development partners and provides leadership to the early recovery cluster. While rapid deployments – as was done in case of Nepal – is appropriate, greater attention was needed in developing and communicating UNDP's strategic positioning.
- UNDP rightly identified debris management in post-earthquake situations a key need in most contexts. However, careful analysis is needed where UNDP can add significant value according to its niche and competence. While concentrating on debris management, UNDP needs to ensure prioritizing support to the government and cluster in developing an overall recovery strategy, on the one hand, and rehabilitation of functioning public infrastructure and services in the immediate aftermath of a major earthquake, on the other.
- UNDP's response was particularly innovative with regard to a debris management app it developed in partnership with Microsoft, and in the way it made extensive use of national UN volunteers to support the response.
- UNDP offers best value in disaster response in areas where it has pre-existing programmes and expertise that can be scaled up rapidly.

Operational Response

Findings

50. After the earthquake, UNDP triggered the activation of Fast-Track Procedures (FTPs) for dealing with emergency finance, procurement and recruitment. However, interviews at country level suggest that UNDP Nepal at times was unable to take full advantage of this due to lack of experience with using FTPs and there were delays which could have been avoided.

51. At the CO level, UNDP had prepared a Business Continuity Plan in 2013 which was not updated after that, and the Plan was not fully activated in the manner envisaged in it. As a number of staff had changed during the intervening period, there was a need for periodic updating and orientation which were not done. As a result, despite being fully aware of the earthquake risks, the CO was not fully prepared. Despite this, at least key operations colleagues were familiar with the roles and responsibilities in post-crisis situations, and minimum essential operational procedures were activated as a result.²² In the initial weeks, the CO office premises was not considered safe until the structure was assessed. Most of the national staff were directly or indirectly affected by the earthquake and they expected emergency practical support (tents/temporary accommodation, water, security updates, etc.) from UNDP on the lines of what was reportedly provided by other agencies,²³ but UNDP could not meet these.²⁴ It is understood that learning from this, UNDP Nepal now has developed a protocol to meet such exigencies so that staff receive a minimum level of immediate support during emergencies.

²² The BCP could not be implemented fully as prescribed in the BCP document. Since Kathmandu valley was not impacted as much as other rural areas, communications (mobile, internet, transport etc.) were operational.

²³ Key informant interviews showed that several other UN agencies and NGOs have a standard practice of allocating small budget for immediate support needs of staff to meet emergency needs.

²⁴ Subsequently UNDP did provide one-off monetary compensation up to USD 2,000 for house repair to each staff who lost their home. Option of advance salary for 10 days and emergency leave was also offered.

Lessons

- With staff changes, training, orientation and updating of preparedness/business continuity plan (BCP) need to be undertaken every six months.
- CO staff need orientation and training for effective utilization of FTP to avoid reverting back to HQ for clarification and clearances.
- When local staff and families are seriously affected in a disaster, UNDP must try to immediately provide a minimum basic survival assistance (tents, food, water, medicines, assistance with transport, etc.) for a few days immediately after a disaster. Ideally this should be a UN System-wide preparedness and a standardized package of assistance (tents, food, water, medicines and other necessary relief items) to all affected UN staff to avoid staff of different UN agencies receiving different assistance packages.

Inter-Agency Coordination

Findings

52. The Early Recovery (ER) cluster was activated by day 2 after the earthquake, and it initially selected four areas of focus: debris management, restoration of governance and public services, livelihoods and rehabilitation of community infrastructure. According to key informants, the government later said that it would do the latter on its own and did not require the cluster to work on it. UNDP coordinated ER interventions in 14 districts in collaboration with district disaster relief committees (DDRC). In each district, a district coordinator was appointed by UNDP, though recruiting them took time. **UNDP demonstrated flexibility and moved several people from its on-going projects to support the cluster.**

53. UNDP was able to deploy an experienced and trained ER cluster coordinator who knew the country. ER cluster was activated by UNDP jointly with the Ministry of Federal Affairs and Local Development (MoFALD) by day 2 and its first meeting was held immediately thereafter, attracting significant participation from humanitarian agencies. This was significant and recognized that in natural disasters **the gap between relief and recovery phase is not big as affected communities begin their recovery efforts immediately after a disaster, though it may take a few years before full recovery takes place. UNDP also offered the services of a senior recovery adviser to the Resident Coordinator's office which was not taken up by the RC/HC on the ground that the latter already had adequate capacity.**

54. The separation of UNDP's programme response on ER and its cluster coordination role was not always clear. Stakeholders in the cluster saw UNDP imposing its own priorities as cluster focus – that the three pillars of UNDP's own programme²⁵ became, verbatim, the priorities of the cluster as well is cited as an example. There was no clear vision or strategy for the overall cluster or attempt to develop a pathway from relief to early recovery through to recovery. One donor noted that **UNDP's focus on debris for its own response and fundraising took its attention away from supporting the government and cluster in developing an overall strategy.** After an initial bout of enthusiasm, interest in the cluster waned and attendance in cluster meetings dropped as

²⁵ The pillars were: debris management; assessment of public and private buildings and restoration of community infrastructures; and restoration of public service delivery.

it failed to create a platform for dialogue with government on overall recovery. As was noted in the Humanitarian Country Team AAR,²⁶ while there were sectoral plans developed, a common longer-term joint strategy on recovery was missing. Considering the delay in preparing recovery framework and setting up the National Reconstruction Authority (NRA), it would have been strategic for UNDP to provide technical support for developing multi-sector/cluster early recovery plan. The PDNA and Livelihood Assessment (October 2015) could have served as solid foundation for a potential joint strategy on early recovery/recovery, developed much before the PDRF (May 2016). Looking back, around the time when cluster system was closing, UNDP's ER coordinator was leaving, and there was a gap period where no one on behalf of UNDP could support the GoN on developing a common longer-term strategy.

55. The humanitarian system, including large bi-lateral humanitarian donors are increasingly emphasizing the need for greater cash response in post-disaster situations. Some donors (such as DFID) are even going to the extent of suggesting that cash should be the default response in future. This does raise opportunities and challenges in terms of financial infrastructure accessible to the poor and vulnerable, local economies and market mechanism, anti-corruption and transparency mechanisms etc. Expertise in this area is still in a state of infancy and several organizations/networks are working on it, though not always in a coherent manner. **An organization like UNDP could uniquely position itself by developing capacity to provide advice and guidance to governments and donors in creating inclusive financial infrastructure to deal with challenges of a scaled-up cash based response.**

56. External stakeholders (donors and NGOs in particular) observed that the UN in general was weak in advocating with the GoN and DPs on financing mechanisms for recovery. The leadership of the RCO (and UNDP) on this was missing. The WB was much smarter and was able to take a lead on this. Besides, donors complained that several UN agencies approached them for funding on similar kind of work, without any coordination among them. After three months of the earthquake, the GoN re-imposed custom duties on supplies brought in by NGOs and other humanitarian agencies – an issue which donors/NGOs felt could have been taken up jointly by RCO/UNDP and OCHA for dialogue with the GoN.

57. OCHA started folding up its presence in the districts from August-September 2015, leaving a vacuum in coordination. NGOs interviewed indicated that they would have expected some **leadership from the RCO and UNDP in providing a strategic steer on recovery during this period, particularly after OCHA had left.** This was partly done in three districts where UNDP positioned District Coordinators and Information Management Officers. After OCHA pulled out, UNDP supported the district administration to establish and lead District Recovery & Reconstruction Network. A critical issue that needs addressing at the Inter Agency Standing Committee (IASC) level is managing the gap left behind by OCHA's premature departure while relief and early recovery work is still going on as happened in Nepal.

Lessons

- UNDP needs to ensure that it 'firewalls' the early recovery cluster role from its own early recovery programme in the future. This would require greater awareness among CO staff of cluster roles, responsibilities and lines of accountability.

²⁶ Nepal Earthquake Humanitarian Country Team After Action Review, UN Nepal, December, 2015 (pp4)

- UNDP needs to develop, working with local and national institutions (and UN Capital Development Fund), specialized expertise in providing support (inclusive financial infrastructure, market and local economy assessments, cash transfer technology, transparency and assurance mechanisms etc.) to cash-based response which is increasingly expanding in post-disaster response.
- Advocacy needed at IASC level to agree transition mechanism to coordinate recovery after departure of OCHA, especially where national capacity to coordinate international response is weak.

Resource Mobilization

Findings

58. The start-up funds for the response came from CRU/BPPS and CPR TTF.²⁷ The immediate release of USD 160,000 from TRAC 1.1.3 for coordination and assessment and USD 1 million from the CPR TTF to the CO was vital for launching the response. Besides this, working with MoFALD and development partners, UNDP got funds from LGCDP released immediately to each affected VDC and municipality for ER activities immediately after the earthquake. DPs agreed to fund temporary structures for 178 VDC buildings which were totally damaged. The CO was also successful in mobilizing additional funds for emergency livelihoods support to beneficiaries of its existing microenterprise programme. Although the Flash Appeal launched on 29 April 2015 did not directly raise any funds for UNDP, responding to the appeal, the Government of Japan provided USD 1 million to UNDP on 21 May 2015 for debris management.

59. Donor partners were flexible with regards to reprogramming resources to allow the CO to respond to the most urgent needs on the ground (Australia, Korea, Denmark, Norway, and Finland). A South-South resource mobilization effort was also successfully implemented with Mauritius contributing USD 1,000,000 for UNDP's livelihood programme.

60. The funding environment in Nepal has been challenging, as transparency and accountability remain big issues across the country. UNDP's programme in Nepal also had some bad reviews²⁸ and an audit during 2013-14 that raised concerns of some donors and may have made fundraising difficult in the early phase. A good communication strategy is crucial for resource mobilization and positioning UNDP amidst the multiple organizations that responded following the earthquake. Immediately after the earthquake, a regional communications specialist based in Bangkok was deployed in Nepal as a "First Responder" which worked very well. That gave global media access to senior managers in Nepal resulting in good media coverage for UNDP. An excellent ExpRes roster communications officer was also sent as part of the SURGE mission to support the Country Office. However, all this did not gain much traction with donors. At least a couple of regular donors to UNDP Nepal's programme commented that UNDP did not develop clear communication messages for engaging with DPs and did not package its work in a way that made a good case for resource mobilization.

²⁷ CPRTTF is now replaced by Emergency Development Responses for Crisis and Recovery (EDRCR) funding window, managed by BPPS.

²⁸ A mid-term review of a flagship risk reduction project, Comprehensive Disaster Risk Management Programme (CDRMP), undertaken in 2013 was highly critical of UNDP's delivery capacity and overall contribution to project outcomes.

61. It is reported that several offers came from private sector companies in Nepal to support the response, but UNDP was not able to capitalize these as there was no clear approach to engage with the private sector. A template for private sector fundraising was made available and shared with the CO. Agreements were signed with Chinese and Japanese private sector companies (USD 125,000 mobilized). Intel foundation also provided USD 330,000 to UNDP Nepal.

Lessons

- The inclusion of a communications specialist in the first responder team enabled UNDP get good media coverage and this practice should continue in future. Additionally, working with programme team the communications staff need to develop clear communication messages for key stakeholders like DPs, government and other humanitarian agencies.
- UNDP should finalize a clear offer to the private sector in the future to pursue and receive support and funding from the private sector in crisis contexts.

Key Achievements and Recommendations for the Future

No	Key Achievements	Recommendations for the Future
Corporate Crisis Response Mechanism		
1	The activation of CB and triangular communication involving the CO, BRH and HQ worked very well to steer initial response and support the CO.	1. The role of CMST was crucial in success of the CB and ensuring that CB decisions were followed up at various ends.
2	SURGE deployment was rapid and appropriate with right mix of expertise with national, regional and international experience, and undertaken with active participation of the CO.	2. SURGE team members, once deployed, need to agree their leave plans with the CO, especially when they are deployed for very short periods (4-6 weeks).
Programmatic Response		
1	UNDP was able to apply its SOPs for Immediate Crisis Response and succeeded in mobilizing a whole-of-UNDP response and a substantial number of experts for early response, including activation of ER cluster.	1. While focusing on getting the programme interventions going, a clear articulation of how UNDP would work with the GoN, other UN agencies, clusters and DPs towards developing a short- and long-term recovery strategy with a long-term vision is required to in the first few weeks.
2	While rapid deployments as was done in case of Nepal is appropriate and helped launch UNDP's initial response, greater attention was needed in developing and communicating UNDP's strategic positioning.	2. UNDP's response should be determined by how it positions itself early on in support of the government's overall recovery planning and strategy, and how it engages with various development partners and provides leadership to the early recovery clusters.

3	UNDP's leadership of the PDNA process, particularly in ensuring that PDNA addressed vulnerability and gender issues, is unanimously acknowledged as its most significant contribution.	3. During and after a PDNA, UNDP needs to ensure that it has good capacity to develop a well-articulated strategy and vision, and communicate these with DPs and government agencies.
4	UNDP produced a SURGE plan within two weeks of the disaster which identified three areas of focus: livelihoods and economic recovery; restoration of local governance function; and national capacities for recovery planning and DRR.	4. The SURGE plan needs to take into account clear analysis of interventions by other key actors, government priorities and donor environment in the country, besides needs of affected communities. To this extent, some form of assessment or rapid scan is needed 2-3 weeks after the disaster to determine UNDP's priorities.
5	UNDP rightly identified debris management as a critical need to focus on, and launched a response focusing on private houses which linked debris removal with cash for work for affected families, besides providing training to rural house owners in safe demolition. While the debris management work gained good visibility in the 3 VDCs UNDP supported, it was very small in scale compared to the need in the 14 most-affected districts.	5. Careful analysis is needed where UNDP can add significant value according to its niche and competence. While UNDP needs to pay attention to its own response (debris clearance, for example), this should not be allowed to take attention away from supporting the government in developing an overall strategy, on the one hand, and ensuring rehabilitation of functioning public infrastructure and services in the immediate aftermath of a major earthquake, on the other.
6	Collaboration with Microsoft on debris management application and safe demolition education campaigns were appreciated and used by many agencies.	6. Promoting innovations and private sector engagement (with UNDP and governments) as some of the key focus of UNDP in disaster response could position it distinctly from other humanitarian agencies.
7	Partnership with UNV in mobilizing 90 UN volunteer engineers who administered implementation of cash-for-work activities on the ground.	7. Deploying UN volunteers instead of International Consultants meant that the former were highly effective in building rapport with and in rapidly assimilating into communities, thus enhancing UNDP's image among partners on the ground as an organization that works with volunteers and promotes practice of volunteerism.
8	Rapidly launching appropriate livelihoods rehabilitation programme for affected families.	8. UNDP's response works best when it is linked to and builds on its ongoing programmes and competence.

Operational Response		
1	In the CO, a preparedness plan and BCP existed and multiple training and orientation were conducted 2-3 years before the earthquake.	1. With staff changes, training, orientation and updating of preparedness/BCP need to be undertaken every six months
2	Fast-track procedure for finance, procurement and recruitment was activated rapidly.	2. Although FTP was activated, the CO had to revert back to HQ for approvals frequently on recruitment. Additionally, lack of orientation of CO staff in implementing FTP sometimes caused delays.
3		3. If staff are seriously affected, COs need to have discretion to allocate small funds to cover essential expenses for providing basic survival assistance to national staff.
Inter-Agency Coordination		
1	UNDP demonstrated flexibility and moved several people from its on-going projects to support cluster.	1. UNDP needs to ensure that it 'firewalls' its early recovery cluster role from its own early recovery interventions in future.
2		2. UNDP needs to develop, working with local and national institutions (and UNCDF), specialized expertise in providing support (inclusive financial infrastructure, market and local economy assessments, cash transfer technology, transparency and assurance mechanisms etc.) to cash-based response which is increasingly expanding in post-disaster response.
3	After the early departure of OCHA, UNDP did deploy district recovery coordinators and information management staff in 3 districts to fill the gap.	3. Advocacy needed at IASC level to agree transition mechanism to coordinate recovery after departure of OCHA, especially where national capacity to coordinate international response is weak.
4	UNDP and RCO were weak in advocating with the GoN and DPs on financing mechanisms for recovery.	4. Dialogue with DPs and governments on financing mechanisms for early recovery and reconstruction needs to start immediately after a disaster and continuously developed during and after PDNA.

Resource Mobilization		
1	Immediate release of startup funds and reprogrammed resources worked very well.	1. Clear articulation of a medium- and long-term vision is needed to engage with donors early on in the response. Towards this end, deployment of senior communication staff capable of working with programme team to develop clear communication messages for donors is crucial.

Annex I: Background and Reference Documents

Changing the Narrative – Building Back Better in Nepal, RELRP Project document, UNDP Nepal, 2015

Corporate Standard Operating Procedure for Immediate Crisis Response, UNDP, Draft vers. 3.0, April 2016

DFID Nepal Earthquake Response Lessons Review Report, DFID, 16 September 2015

Minutes of the Crisis Board meeting between April-June, 2015

Nepal Earthquake 2015 Post Disaster Needs Assessment – Executive Summary, Government of Nepal/ National Planning Commission, 2015

Nepal Earthquake: Humanitarian Country Team After Action Review – Workshop Summary Report, UN Nepal, 2015

Post Disaster Recovery Framework, Government of Nepal, 2016

STAIT Learning Review – Senior Transformative Agenda Implementation Team, January 2016

Supporting Nepal in Building Back Better – UNDP Strategy for Earthquake Recovery Assistance, UNDP, May 2016

Terms of Reference SURGE Planning Team – NEPAL, 29 April 2015

UNDP Annual Report, UNDP 2015

UNDP Crisis Response Unit – Introduction Package

UNDP SURGE Plan Response to Nepal Earthquake of April 2015, May to October 2015

Annex II: List of People Consulted

#	Name	Title	Bureau	Duty Station	Nepal SURGE function	Method
1	Ainsley Hemming		DFAT Nepal	Kathmandu	-	T
2	Amy Gill	Policy Specialist (Governance)	UNDP BPPS	New York	SURGE team member (PDNA)	FT
3	Anil Chandrika	Programme Specialist	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu	LGCDP Coordinator	F
4	Bandana Risal	Senior Programme Specialist	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu	Governance team	F
5	Bettina Woll	Crisis Response Coordinator	UNDP CRU	New York	Team Leader, Crisis Response Coordination	T
6	Bibhor Baral		UNDP Nepal	Sindhupalchok	District Coordinator	FF
7	Bruno Lemarquis	Deputy Director, Crisis Response Unit	UNDP CRU	New York	Oversight - Management of the support + SURGE planning team member + CB member	T & FT
8	Charu Bist	Livelihoods Specialist	UNDP BPPS	New York	SURGE planning member + SURGE team member (focus on livelihood)	FT
9	Chinatsu Endo	Programme Analyst	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu	Implementation of the response	F
10	Dennis Curry	Early Recovery Cluster Coordinator	Consultant		SURGE team member (focus on Early Recovery)	T
11	Fabrizio Andreuzzi	Programme Specialist	UNDP CRU	New York		FT
12	Heema Khadka	Assistant Country Director	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu		F
13	Henrik F. Larsen	Country Director, Angola	UNDP RBA	Angola	CB member + SURGE team member (programme)	T
14	Jamie Mcgoldrick	Resident Coordinator, Yemen	UN Nepal	Kathmandu	Resident Coordinator/Humanitarian Coordinator	T
15	Jason Katz		PACT Nepal	Kathmandu	Senior Recovery Director	T
16	Jo Scheuer	Chief of Profession, Climate Change & Disaster Risk Reduction	UNDP BPPS	New York	Crisis Board member (alternate) + SURGE planning team member (focus on programme)	FT
17	Kedar Babu Dhungana	Senior Project Manager, CDRMP	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu	Senior Project Manager, CDRMP	F
18	Krishna Vatsa	Senior Recovery Advisor	UNDP BPPS	New York	SURGE team member (focus on PDNA)	T
19	Kristin Ray		USAID Nepal	Kathmandu	-	T

20	Lin Cao	CO Liaison and Coordination Advisor	UNDP RBAP	Bangkok	Crisis Management Team member	FT
21	Manish Gautam		UNDP Nepal	Sindhupalchok	District Coordinator	FF
22	Mohita Joshi		UNDP Nepal	Gorkha	Gorkha	FF
23	Moiria Reddick		RCO Nepal	Kathmandu	Former NRRC Coordinator	T
24	Niyam Maharajan		Government of Nepal	Kathmandu	Former LGCDP focal point	F
25	Pete La Raus		Save the Children, Nepal	Kathmandu	Earthquake Response Director	F
26	Rachel Routley		RCO Nepal	Kathmandu	Resilience Adviser	F
27	Ramraj Narasimhan	Technical Specialist (DRM)	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu	SURGE team member (DRM)	F
28	Rekha Das	Early Recovery Advisor	UNDP CRU	Geneva	Support from the GCER	FT
29	Renaud Meyer	Country Director	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu	Oversight - Management of the response	F
30	Rishi Acharya		Government of Nepal	Kathmandu	Under Secretary, MoFALD	F
31	Rita Missal	Programme Specialist (Recovery)	UNDP BPPS	New York	Crisis Management Support Team member	FT
32	Sam Rose		DFID Nepal	Kathmandu	Former DFID Humanitarian Adviser	T
33	Sanny Ramos Jegillos	Practice Coordinator (Recovery)	UNDP BPPS	Bangkok	SURGE team member (PDNA)	FT
34	Santosh Sharma	Emergency Response Coordinator	CARE Nepal	Kathmandu		F
35	Saumik De	Programme Specialist (Deployments)	UNDP CRU	New York	Managed deployments	T
36	Seeta Giri	Recovery Advisor	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu	Implementation of the response	F
37	Sophie Kemkhadze	Deputy Country Director	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu	Oversight - Management of the response	F
38	Thierry Prouteau	Programme Analyst	UNDP CRU	New York		FT
39	Ugo Blanco	Regional Advisor	UNDP RBLAC	New York	SURGE planning team member (focus on debris)	FT
40	Yam Nath Sharma	Assistant Country Director	UNDP Nepal	Kathmandu		F

Annex III: Terms of Reference - After Action Review for Crisis Response to Earthquakes in Nepal, UNDP, 2015

Duty Station :	HOME BASED + Travel to Kathmandu and New York
Languages Required :	English
Starting Date : (date when the selected candidate is expected to start)	September -2016
Expected Duration of Assignment :	8 weeks (including travels)
Background on the earthquakes in Nepal 2015	
The two massive earthquakes that struck Nepal on 25th April and 12th May with a magnitude of 7.8 and 7.3 respectively left hundreds of thousands families without shelter and livelihoods and left the country in dire need of immediate crisis response and assistance. Decades of poor development, a prolonged political transition, a lack of compliance with building codes, as well as chronic vulnerabilities, such as local poverty, helped exacerbate risks in the seismically active region. The quakes took a heavy toll of lives and property and millions of people were affected in a variety of ways. Roads, bridges, water supplies, schools, hospitals in the main cities and in rural areas across more than two-third of Nepal's 75 districts suffered severe damages.	
UNDP's Immediate Response	
In the immediate aftermath of the devastating earthquake that struck Nepal on 25 April 2015, and in line with UNDP's Standard Operating Procedures for crisis response, a SURGE planning team was deployed to Nepal from 30 April to 9 May 2015, as requested by the Crisis Board in agreement with the Nepal Country Office. The purpose of the SURGE mission was to develop an integrated programmatic and operational plan that both responded to the immediate needs of the crisis, but also assisted the CO in thinking through a core resilience-based approach to recovery that would support the CO in positioning UNDP in this agenda going forward. The second earthquake hit after the SURGE planning team had finalized the mission but the effects and ramifications of the second quake was processed and included in the finalization of the SURGE plan.	
In early April 2015, UNDP had just adopted its new Crisis Response Strategy with the commitment to develop existing signature products for early recovery programming into comprehensive crisis response packages with elements that combine programme, operations, communications, deployable capacity and resource mobilization, among others. The crisis response packages concretely express UNDP commitment to step-up its capacity to be prepared and capable to respond to a crisis. When a crisis hits, UNDP will be more predictable and will quickly activate the packages adopting a whole UNDP approach geared towards supporting a country office to rapidly get to scale when engaging in crisis response and recovery. Nepal L2 crisis was the first and very initial testing ground for the crisis response packages approach and (by then) partially developed elements. In particular, the emergency livelihoods through community infrastructure, and debris/solid waste management crisis response package were utilized. The After Action Review (AAR) would offer useful insights in making the package as much as possible adherent to the needs of UNDP CO and key partners in the immediate aftermath of a similar disaster. Importantly, the AAR would make relevant recommendations for UNDP investment in country office crisis preparedness measures and tools.	
In this context, it is expected that an AAR will provide a comprehensive assessment of UNDP's response to the earthquakes in Nepal. The AAR will aim to inform the continuous enhancements of UNDP's crisis response systems, tools and processes by gathering facts and perceptions related to UNDP's response and suggesting actionable recommendations to improve UNDP's future response operations. The review will therefore hopefully contribute to the overall improvement of the	

timeliness and effectiveness of UNDP response to emergencies resulting from disasters due to natural hazards.

The AAR is in line with corporate procedures corresponding to this magnitude of crisis, and will serve as an internal learning exercise. Key learnings from this review may be shared with partners as a part of collective learnings and experience sharing.

Objective and Scope of the AAR

The objective of the AAR is to examine the performance of UNDP with respect to the response to the earthquake in Nepal, and highlight lessons learned that would help strengthen the functioning, performance and efficiency of UNDP response to disasters, including elements pertaining to UNDPs corporate and country level programmatic and operational response; UN and interagency coordination; contribution to PDNA and recovery processes. The AAR will draw forward looking recommendations for the corporate crisis preparedness and response tools in view of their application to future crisis response situations.

The AAR exercise will address directly or indirectly the following areas:

Overall Response

- Examine the UNDP's response in the context of an L2 crisis with special emphasis on compliance with crisis response systems and processes (e.g. corporate SOP) at global, regional and country level. This includes i) timeliness and effectiveness of strategic decisions and actions by decision makers and other key stakeholders in the organization in order to respond to the crisis; ii) internal communication and coordination flows within UNDP to support the CO's efforts to respond to the crisis; iii) timeliness and effectiveness to quickly scale up UNDP Nepal's capacity to undertake immediate crisis response activities and pose the foundations for recovery;
- Review UNDP's overall preparedness for response [CO, Regional, global] including the decision-making processes and their efficiency in the context of corporate response - with the view to inform the finalization of the SOPs for UNDP's immediate crisis response.
- Examine UNDP's ability to take on a "whole of UNDP" approach to the response and recovery efforts;
- Produce a cost-benefit analysis or return of investment analysis on the SURGE;
- Assess how UNDP technical and programmatic expertise was leveraged during the earthquakes response;
- Examine whether recommendations tabled during previous After Action reviews were implemented in responding to the earthquakes;

Programmatic Response

- Review the application of UNDP's Crisis Response Packages' approach and elements (some of them not completed during the crisis response period).
- Review the pertinence of UNDP's recovery programme formulation and the choices that were made in terms of programme priorities; the reasons why those choices were made; and overall programmatic performance;
- Examine whether adjustments were made to the existing country programme in response to the earthquakes (including the identification of new programmes);
- Draw lessons on the sustainability of UNDP Programmatic activities and function performed by SURGE Advisors and positioning in response of the earthquakes;
- Examine the role SURGE Advisors played in programme development and implementation, programme realignment and resources mobilization;
- Provide a cost-benefit analysis on the added value provided by the SURGE Advisors in the elaboration and delivery of programmes at the Country Office level;
- Examine the collaboration between the experts deployed under the SURGE modality and the Programmatic staff in country, at global level and in the Regional Hub;

Operational Response

- Review the efficiency and effectiveness of immediate crisis response standard operating procedures, as well as analyze their application in the context of the response. This includes but is not limited to the application of Fast Track procedures and rapid response processes (financing, deployments, recruitment, procurement, etc.);
- Review the relevance and timeliness of the SURGE work plan, and quality of SURGE deployments, including when relevant of UNDP Stand-by partners, and management of SURGE advisors in country;
- Examine the operational bottlenecks and constraints faced by the CO in terms of both operations and programme implementation;

UN and Interagency Coordination:

The effectiveness and adequacy of UNDP's engagement with the broader humanitarian action. Including a review of:

- The extent of UNDP's coordination and cooperation with key humanitarian partners on the ground;
- UNDP's leadership of the Early Recovery Cluster on the ground in supporting recovery and UNDP capacity to attract partners and resources to the cluster;
- Clarity of UNDP's role and actions vis-à-vis other partners, including but not limited to other clusters, IFIs, and NGOs;
- UNDP's ability to link immediate early recovery to longer term recovery efforts;
- UNDP's support to Government coordination capacities and UNDP's engagement in the wider planning processes for recovery with the government, IFIs and other key stakeholders.

UNDP's Engagement in and Influence on Assessment Processes

- UNDP's ability to build synergies and mainstream the recovery agenda in the needs assessment processes (such as MIRA and PDNA) and humanitarian funding instruments;

Communication and Resource Mobilization:

- Examine the timeliness and effectiveness of communication, including relationship with media, and resource mobilization efforts;
- Review UNDP's level of success in mobilizing funds from humanitarian funding sources, including but not limited to Flash Appeal and CERF Rapid Response Grant.
- Examine internal and external factors that impacted donor funding decisions, identifying areas for improvement.
- Assess donor response to the UNDP programme, identifying gaps and areas for improvement;
- Assess donor response to the overall ER agenda and UNDP leadership of the ER cluster;

Deliverables

The review will cover UNDP's response to the earthquakes in Nepal and will focus on the period starting 25th April 2015 to 25th October 2015, which corresponds to the SURGE period. The review cover UNDP HQ, regional presence in Bangkok and the Nepal Country Office as well as all aspects of UNDPs response and its role in the interagency arenas.

The recommendations will have a forward-looking view, with aim to identifying best practices and innovations that can be systematized, as well as practices that need to be avoided in the future. It will also define areas for further investment and improvement in the response. In addition the ARR will provide:

- A work plan with methodology and timeline for the AAR exercise based on the elements outlined in the objective and scope section of the ToR that will be prioritized with UNDP
- A timeline with an overview of facts and events;
- An overview of recommendations implemented / not implemented from past AARs;
- An inception report on the initial findings to be delivered prior to the Country visits;
- A draft report on best practices, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on key issues as highlighted in the objectives above;
- A forward looking Action Plan for implementing recommendations with a focus on operationalizing the new corporate SOP for immediate crisis response and relevant UNDP crisis response packages, and UNDP's role in transcending the humanitarian-development divide in a post-disaster context;
- A final report on best practices, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on key issues as highlighted in the objectives above;
- A two pager document summarizing the key findings and recommendations of the AAR exercise;
- A debriefing meeting in Kathmandu as well as a multi-stakeholder sharing of the findings and recommendations, such as a presentation to key UNDP stakeholders from UNDP Nepal, Bangkok and New York.

Methodology, Timeline and Travel

An independent consultant will be recruited to conduct the after action review. He/she will report to the Crisis Response Unit (CRU) Rapid Response and Preparedness Team who will oversee the day-to-day management of the team, with support from the Crisis Coordination Team (Asia Pacific, Arab States and ECIS) and the Regional Bureau for Asia and the Pacific (RBAP). The final report will be presented to RBAP and CRU for final endorsement.

Timeline for the review will be September -October 2016.

Information will be gathered from primary and secondary sources. This includes desk reviews, key informant interviews in headquarters with central and regional bureaus involved, the country office and deployed personnel. Meetings with partners and stakeholders, field visits, focus group meetings with stakeholders and surveys.

The consultant will travel to Kathmandu (Nepal) and to New York (UNDP HQ). The consultant is expected to spend five (5) days in Kathmandu for country based consultations and two (2) days in New York for final presentation and debriefing²⁹. The consultant will be responsible for her/his own travel arrangement and travel and per diem costs will be included in the financial proposal.

Description of Responsibilities :

Under the direct supervision of the Program Specialist (CRU Rapid Response and Preparedness Team), and in coordination with CRU Crisis Coordination Team (Asia Pacific, Arab States and ECIS) as well as RBAP, the consultant for the AAR exercise will:

1. Lead the AAR exercise from preparation to final delivery in close collaboration with CRU, RBAP and the Country Office.

²⁹ This number of days is estimated and can be further adjusted during the work plan/methodological discussion

2. Lead the development of questionnaire, methodology, mission schedule and work plan for the AAR.
3. Gather and review all the necessary documents related to the Global, Regional and Country level response, including relevant procedures and practices.
4. Draft an inception report on initial findings, including an overview of recommendations implemented / not implemented from past AARs, and an overview of the facts and events.
5. Lead the consultations processes related to the AAR, including preparatory meetings, surveys, in country visit (Kathmandu), focus group discussions, debriefings and final report presentation by liaising and coordinating with all relevant stakeholders.
6. Lead a cost-benefit analysis or Return On Investment Analysis for SURGE.
7. Produce a draft AAR report, compile and address comments that arise from the draft report internal circulation.
8. Produce a final and consolidated AAR report, a two pager document summarizing the key findings and recommendations, as well as a forward looking Action Plan for implementing recommendations for submission to the UNDP CRU and RBAP.
9. Facilitate a multi- stakeholder workshop in UNDP HQ in New York presenting the AAR findings and recommendations.

Competencies :

Core Competencies:

Ethics & Values:

- Demonstrating / Safeguarding Ethics and Integrity;
- Demonstrates and promotes the highest standard of integrity, impartiality, fairness and incorruptibility in all matters affecting his/her work and status.

Functional Competencies:

Organizational Awareness:

- Demonstrate corporate knowledge and sound judgment understands the structure and hierarchy of UN/UNDP, process flows throughout the organization, products and services, their measures of effectiveness, and perceptions of clients;
- Excellent knowledge of humanitarian and recovery issues and internationally-agreed humanitarian and recovery standards;

Working in Teams:

- Acting as a team player and facilitating team work;
- Works collaboratively with colleagues inside UN/UNDP as well as its partners and other stakeholders to pursue common goals.

Communicating Information and Ideas:

- Facilitating and encouraging open communication in the team, communicating effectively;
- Delivers verbal/written information in a timely, clear, organized and easily understood manner;
- Excellent oral and written skills to develop knowledge products in relevant areas;
- Strong communication skills and the ability to listen and take direction and leadership from others.

Self-Management & Emotional Intelligence:

- Creating synergies through self-control tolerates conditions of stress, uncertainty or ambiguity and continues to maintain a positive outlook and to work productively.

Knowledge Sharing & Continuous Learning:

- Ability to efficiently handle and share information and knowledge.

Functional competencies:

- Knowledge of emergency preparedness and response, including early recovery policies, and inter-agency mechanisms;
- Ability to adopt and apply methodology and tools for After Action Reviews (AAR) in emergency and crisis situations;
- Excellent drafting and report writing skills.

Qualifications :

Education:

- Advanced University degree (Master's Degree or equivalent) International Relations and/or Regional Studies, Project Management, Human Resources or Information Technology.

Experience :

- At least 10 years of professional experience providing advisory support and technical advice in the area of emergency and crisis response and recovery.
- Experience in conducting After Action Reviews (AAR) for emergency and humanitarian response. Proven record of producing AAR reports an asset.
- Experience in emergency preparedness and response planning, reporting and coordination;
- Exposure or relevant experience to develop and/or manage knowledge management systems and capacity development exercises;
- Field experience in emergency response and preparedness is an asset;
- Proven ability to work under pressure with quick turnaround deadlines, and to deliver in a timely manner within cost and quality standards;
- Computer proficient and well versed in the use of Microsoft Office and other relevant Internet, Excel and Word;
- Proven ability to work in a multicultural setting.

Language:

- Proficiency in English is a must;
- Proficiency in one or several other working UN language(s) would be an added advantage.

Application and Payment Procedures

Interested candidates are encouraged to apply by submitting as soon as possible the following documents:

- ✓ **Personal CV or P11**, indicating all past experience from similar projects, as well as the contact details (email and telephone number) of the Candidate and at least three (3) professional references;
- ✓ **Brief description** of why the individual considers him/herself as the most suitable for the assignment, and a methodology, on how they will approach and complete the assignment;
- ✓ **Financial Proposal** that indicates the all-inclusive fixed total contract price, supported by a breakdown of costs, including travel and per diem.

A Combined Scoring method – where the qualifications and methodology will be weighted a max. of 70%, and combined with the price offer which will be weighted a max of 30% - will be used toward the selection of the best offer.

Payments under this contract will be delivery-based with the various installments being processed upon receipt of key deliverables, as follow:

Deliverables	Estimated Duration to Complete³⁰	Percentage of full payment
- Draft methodology and work plan - A timeline with an overview of facts and events; - An overview of recommendations implemented / not implemented from past AARs; - An inception report on the initial findings to be delivered prior to the Country visits;	5 days	1st installment: 20% of full payment
- A draft report on best practices, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on key issues as highlighted in the objectives above; - A forward looking Action Plan for implementing recommendations with a focus on operationalizing the new corporate SOP for immediate crisis response and relevant UNDP crisis response packages, and UNDP's role in transcending the humanitarian-development divide in a post-disaster context;	10 days	2nd installment: 50% of full payment
- A final report on best practices, lessons learned and recommendations, focusing on key issues as highlighted in the objectives above; - A two pager document summarizing the key findings and recommendations of the AAR exercise; - A debriefing meeting in Kathmandu as well as a multi-stakeholder sharing of the findings and recommendations, such as a presentation to key UNDP stakeholders from UNDP Nepal, Bangkok and New York.	5 days	3rd installment: 30% of full payment

³⁰ Not binding, for consultant consideration only. The payment will be delivery based only.

Annex IV: Inception Report - After Action Review for Crisis Response to Earthquakes in Nepal, UNDP, 2015

1. The Context and Purpose of the After Action Review

1.1 Introduction

1. This inception report (IR) relates to an after-action review (AAR) of the United Nations Development Programme's (UNDP) response to the Nepal earthquakes³¹ of 2015. The IR details the purpose, objectives, questions and methodology that will underpin the review process and the implementation plan for the review.
2. When the earthquakes struck, UNDP had just adopted its new Crisis Response Strategy that included programme, operations, communications, deployable capacity and resource mobilization, among others. The crisis response strategy concretely expresses UNDP's commitment to step-up its capacity to be prepared and capable of responding to a crisis in a predictable manner. Nepal crisis was the first and very initial testing ground for the evolving crisis response strategy. The AAR is in line with corporate procedures corresponding to this magnitude of crisis,³² and will serve as an internal learning exercise, offering useful insights into how an organisation-wide strategy can support the UNDP country office (CO) and key partners in the immediate aftermath of a similar disaster.

1.2 Objectives and scope of the AAR

3. The overall objective of the AAR is to examine the performance of UNDP with respect to response to the earthquakes in Nepal in the first six months of the response, and highlight lessons learned that would help strengthen the functioning, performance and efficiency of UNDP's response to disasters in future. The focus of the AAR will be on application/deployment of tools, processes and resources in the formative stage of the response (first six months), and draw forward-looking recommendations for the corporate crisis preparedness and response tools in view of their application to future crisis response situations.
4. The specific aspects of the response the AAR is required to examine are provided in the attached (Annex 1) Terms of Reference (TOR). In brief, these are:
 - *Overall response* – compliance with crisis response systems and processes; timeliness and effectiveness of decision making; internal communications and coordination; scale up CO capacity for immediate response and establishing foundations for recovery; overall preparedness to response;

³¹ There were two major earthquakes in a span of three weeks – the first one was on 25 April, followed by another on 12 May, though the latter was far less devastating than the first.

³² Nepal earthquake was classified as L2 emergency as per UNDP's crisis response SOP. UNDP has 3 levels of crises depending on several factors: (i) L1 – where the CO has capacity to manage the response with some ad hoc support from HQ; (ii) L2 – where the CO can manage the response only with substantial day-to-day support from the HQ/RBAP; and (iii) L3 – corporate emergencies which require the attention of the entire organization due to the scale, complexity, resource requirements and interagency/international dimensions of a crisis.

- *Programmatic response* – application of UNDP's crisis response packages;³³ early recovery programme formulation; role of SURGE Advisers in programme development, resource mobilisation and implementation; cost-benefit analysis of SURGE deployment; collaboration between SURGE staff and in-country programme staff;
 - *Operational response* – efficiency and effectiveness of crisis response and standard operating procedures (SOP); country-level business continuity plan; procurement of goods and services; recruitment of personnel, quality of SURGE deployments including stand-by partners, and management of SURGE advisers;
 - *UN and interagency coordination* – UNDP's coordination and leadership of early recovery (ER) cluster; UNDP's ability to link immediate early recovery to longer term recovery efforts; UNDP's participation in the inter-cluster coordination and advocacy of early recovery; UNDP's support to Government coordination capacities and UNDP's engagement in the wider planning processes for recovery with the government, international financial institutions (IFIs) and other key stakeholders;
 - *Assessment of needs* - UNDP's ability to build synergies and mainstream the recovery agenda in the needs assessment processes and humanitarian funding instruments;
 - *Communication and resource mobilisation* - timeliness and effectiveness of communication, including relationship with media, and resource mobilization efforts; level of success in mobilizing funds from humanitarian funding sources; donor response to the UNDP programme, identifying gaps and areas for improvement.
5. The scope of the review covers the period starting 25 April to 25 October 2015 which corresponds to the SURGE period, and will cover all aspects of UNDP's (headquarters, regional bureau and CO) management and delivery of the response during this period, including UNDP's role and support to interagency processes. As this is an AAR, it is not designed to assess the outcomes and impact on affected communities.

2. Methodology of the AAR

2.1 Key issues emerging from initial scoping

6. Available documents on how the crisis response evolved starting with a first Crisis Board (CB) meeting within 36 hours of the earthquake through to SURGE deployments and recovery plan give the impression that UNDP did implement its SOP which was then prevailing.³⁴ This appears to have brought various parts of the organisation (CO, Regional Bureau for Asia Pacific – RBAP and various departments in the HQ) to work in a coordinated manner. The AAR needs to validate this and examine the effectiveness and quality of the interventions that were made at various points in the first six months.

³³ These were still being developed when the Nepal earthquake struck. The AAR may examine relevant lessons learned on application of foundational elements of the packages.

³⁴ The new SOP development process started on June 1st 2015, so the early phase of the response was not influenced by the new SOP, rather it was the old SOP that was applied.

7. Preliminary research indicates that this will be the first AAR on the response and there are no other internal reviews/evaluations or lessons learning reports for this AAR to draw on. As this AAR comes nearly a year and a half after the earthquake, large part of analysis for this exercise will have to be drawn from piecing together data gleaned from key informant interviews and Focus Group Discussions (FGD), particularly – not exclusively - those who were involved in the first six months of the response (for instance, members of the Crisis Management Team (CMT) in HQ and in the Bangkok Regional Hub, members of the SURGE Planning Team, SURGE deployed personnel from UNDP, individual consultants and stand-by partners, amongst others.)
8. The CO is also interested in undertaking its own AAR, focusing more on programmatic issues covering the first year of the response. It is understood that part of the CO's review process will be taking place while this AAR exercise will be going on. In order to make the two processes complementary and to avoid duplication, it has been suggested that the CO AAR could also draw on the findings and lessons that emerge from this AAR which focuses on the SURGE period, though the former would need to undertake further data gathering to cover the period beyond the SURGE, particularly UNDP's positioning and transition from crisis response to recovery.
9. Besides internal stakeholders (HQ, RBAP and CO), there are several external stakeholders who would also constitute key informants for this AAR, and some of the external documents/reports (evaluation reports on recovery, interagency evaluations, any report by GoN, etc), if available, will also be drawn on. The following stakeholders (Table 1) have been identified as source of information for this review:

Table 1: UNDP AAR stakeholders and their interest in the review

Stakeholder(s)	Role/nature of stakeholders and interest in the evaluation
UNDP HQ	The Crisis Response Unit (CRU), Bureau for Policy and Programme Support (BPPS), Bureau for External Relations and Advocacy (BERA), Bureau for Management Services (BMS) are all important stakeholders in HQ as they provided critical management and operations support to the response.
UNDP CO	The CO is responsible for country level planning and implementation of UNDP operations. The CO is a key stakeholder of the AAR because it has an interest in enhancing its capacity to respond to future disasters based on lessons from the earthquake response. The CO also needs to learn from the evaluation to inform decision-making and if necessary, use the finding to readjust programming and implementation. The particular staff who would be able to make direct contribution to this review are: - Humanitarian Coordinator/Resident Coordination (HC/RC)³⁵ - UNDP Country Director (CD)

³⁵ Though technically not a UNDP CO staff, RC/HC is responsible for oversight of UNDP programs and overall leadership of UN response.

	- Recovery cluster and operations staff (national and international) who were deployed in various roles during the first 6 months of the response.
Regional Bureau for Asia Pacific (RBAP)	In the light of RBAP's strategic and accountability role to the Country Offices (COs) in the region, it has a direct stake in the review. The Regional Director chaired the Crisis Board and in that capacity was responsible for steering the overall response in collaboration with the CO. Additionally, RBAP deployed several staff and provided support to the CO at all stages, including facilitating resources from the HQ. Some of the particular staff of direct interest to this review are: - Regional Director - Deputy Regional Director (and Regional Hub Director) - Cluster Head - Nepal country programme specialist - Operations Adviser - Communications Specialist
Government of Nepal (GoN)	Ministry of Federal Affairs and Local Development (MFALD) is directly involved as nodal ministry coordinating response and recovery, including PDNA. Under MOFALD, Local Governance and Community Development Programme (LGCDP) served as a vehicle for debris management operation. Additionally, Ministry of Urban Development was also involved in debris removal which was a key focus of UNDP in the early phase.
OCHA Nepal	As an Agency responsible for overall coordination of humanitarian response including rapid assessments, Flash Appeal and oversight of clusters, OCHA is a direct stakeholder in the AAR and will have insights on performance of the ER cluster in particular.
Other humanitarian agencies in Nepal	UN Agencies, NGOs and other agencies which were active in early recovery in general and debris removal in particular (IOM)

2.2 Methodological approach and key questions

10. **Mixed-method approach:** The review will use a mixed-method approach, with emphasis on both qualitative and quantitative data, where available, on process and lessons. As this is not an evaluation, the AAR will not assess outputs and outcome of the programme, though intermediate outputs from key activities (SURGE, ER cluster, ER interventions, resource mobilisation, crisis recovery packages) which were the focus of early response in the first six months will be examined. Data collection for the evaluation will be mainly done through documents research, purposively selected key informant interviews (KIIs) with stakeholders and carefully structured focus group discussions (FGDs). Apart from FGDs, a workshop-style interactive discussion with the CO team will also be undertaken as part of the process. A validation workshop in NY to discuss AAR findings and initial recommendations will be organized subsequently after the initial draft is ready.
11. **Review questions:** In line with focus of the review (paragraph 4), the following set of questions has been framed to examine each aspect.

12. *Crisis response – crisis trigger, decision-making and communication, internal coordination, scaling up:*

- Was there a crisis response mechanism in place that the CO & RBAP could use as soon as the earthquake struck? Did the mechanism work well?
- Were lines of communication and authority clear at all levels?
- Did the preliminary situation reports in the first 72 hours provide clear information for decision-making at all levels (for HR/first deployment, resource mobilisation, operations management, logistics, etc), and did it provide a comprehensive picture of the CO capacity and gaps?
- How did the interface between SURGE staff and in-country staff work out to complement the response?
- How well did the Crisis Board function?
- How well did the Country-level decision-making function?
- Were key management decisions timely and clear?
- Were resource allocation decisions timely and appropriate?
- How effective was UNDP coordination
 - o Coordination within UNDP HQs (whole of UNDP approach)
 - o Coordination between UNDP HQs and UNDP Regional/Country Offices

13. *Operational response:*

- Did the CO get necessary support it needed from the RBAP & CRU, and get these on time?
- How well did UNDP manage staff safety, security and support to staff and families affected by the earthquake?
- How well did the rapid deployment/SURGE work – staff secondment/stand-by agreement; timeliness; relevant expertise; clear TOR; briefing & debriefing; logistical support, etc.? Were these gender-sensitive?
- How did the scaling up and scaling back affect the CO capacity and workload? Were there challenges in integrating /meshing the SURGE into existing teams? Any lessons?
- To what extent the SURGE ensured that the CO and responders had capacity at every stage to ensure that UNDP response took gender and environmental issues into account? What specific measures, if any, were undertaken in this regard?
- How effective was the fast-track policy with regard to recruitment, financial management, procurement, etc.?
- How timely were decisions on funds release from CPRTF, TRAC 3 and re-programmed resources? With hindsight, anything could have been done differently, especially with regard to dialogue with donors on reprogrammed resources?

14. *Programmatic response:*

- How did the interface between SURGE staff and in-country staff work out to complement the response?
- The SURGE plan laid emphasis on debris management, assessment of public and private buildings & community infrastructure rehabilitation, as well as restoration on public services – how realistic and effective was the plan?
- Who were the key actors on debris removal and community infrastructure rehabilitation, and what was UNDP's distinctive contribution in these?

- What role did UNDP play in relation to restoring local governance functions?
- What was UNDP's role in emergency employment and livelihoods recovery?
- Did UNDP work on cash-based interventions? If so, what specifically, and how effectively? What lessons for future?
- What was the cost³⁶ of SURGE deployment over the six-month period, and how does it compare with the outputs produced through SURGE deployments?

15. *Resource mobilisation:*

- How adequate and timely were information on needs and situation assessment for resource mobilisation plans to be drawn up? Was UNDP able to produce a coherent resource mobilisation plan on time?
- How useful was the 3-year recovery plan for resource mobilisation and how much funds were raised in the first six months?
- The Flash Appeal (FA) was for USD 5.6 billion – how much of this was received by UNDP? Any lessons for future regarding UNDP's submissions in FA?
- How effectively did UNDP advocate for the interests of UNDP?
- How effectively did UNDP advocate for interests of affected countries?

16. *Interagency coordination:*

- How well did UNDP articulate its role within the overall UN response?
- Was any UNDP staff deployed as part of UNDAC?
- DID UNDP participate in MIRA, and if so, what was the specific contribution made?
- How effectively was UNDP able to provide leadership to the early recovery cluster – information coordination, overall approach, strategy, interface with GoN?
- What was UNDP's specific contribution to the PDNA? To what extent was PDNA owned by the GoN?
- What was the contribution of UNDP in GoN's post-disaster recovery planning?
- How effective was UNDP's coordination?
 - o Coordination with other UN agencies and IFIs
 - o Coordination with host Government
 - o Coordination with donor/support Governments

3. Programme of Work

3.1 AAR activities and steps

17. The review will take the following steps in research, data collection, triangulation, analysis, and reporting:
18. **Scoping, planning & drafting of IR (4 days)**

³⁶ The TOR requires that a cost benefit analysis (CBA) or return on investment for SURGE is worked out. Instead, it has been agreed at the inception stage to carry out a qualitative assessment of the cost and immediate payoff from a few selected interventions like, deployment of first responders.

- Document research: review of key documents – crisis board meeting minutes, UNDP crisis response policies, SOP and frameworks
- Briefing meeting (telephone interviews) – New York & Nepal
- Preliminary analysis of data gathered through the scoping process and preparation of this inception report with methodology and work plan, which will be agreed with the CRU and the CO.

19. Orientation and interviews in New York³⁷ & RBAP (3 days)

- Key informant interviews and finalisation of IR
- Conduct two Focus Group Discussions: Crisis Management Team, and SURGE Planning Team
- Telephone interviews with key stakeholders in RBAP

20. Nepal country visit (7 days including travel)

- Interviews and FGD with CO staff, HC/RC
- Key informant interviews/FGD with external stakeholders (OCHA, IOM, key donor agencies, MFALD, NGOs/other agencies active in debris removal)
- Exit debriefing with CO team at the end of the visit.

21. Data analysis and drafting of 1st draft report (5 days)

1. Data analysis and preliminary findings; establishment of timelines to identify key events and key decision-making points
2. Gender-disaggregated data where available will be used in analysis
 - Triangulation of findings to determine high, medium and low levels of convergence
 - Preparation and submission of initial draft of the report.

22. Presentation of findings and recommendations and discussions on 1st draft (2 days)

- A presentation to UNDP New York of 1st draft report.

23. Final Report (3 days)

- Preparation of second draft (including Executive Summary) based on feedback on the first draft and comments received in New York presentation
- Submission of final report.

3.2 Calendar of work

24. The following schedule is proposed.

Table 2: Schedule of activities and deliverables

	Deliverable	Date
1	Submission of draft inception report	15 September 2016
2.	New York briefings, FGDs and interviews (NY and RBAP)	19-20 September 2016
2	Feedback from UNDP and submission of final IR	21 September 2016
4	Travel to Nepal	24/25 September 2016

³⁷ An orientation visit for 2 days to NY was initially planned. However, as the consultant could not procure an entry clearance to the US, the interviews and discussions will take place over phone.

5	Data gathering in Nepal (KII/FGD including telephone interviews with current and former staff; external stakeholders)	26-30 September 2016
6	Exit debrief in Kathmandu	30 September 2016
7	Submission of 1 st draft to UNDP	10 October 2016
8	UNDP feedback to reviewer	11-25 October 2016
9	Presentation to UNDP (NY)	21 October 2016
10	Submission of final draft to UNDP	31 October 2016

4. Support needed from UNDP in preparation for the AAR

25. UNDP CRU and CO Nepal are requested to set up meetings/interviews. A list of individuals / groups who have been identified through preliminary briefings is attached as Annex 2; HQ and CO are requested to arrange interviews (face-to-face, telephone and FGDs) on the dates indicated in Table 2.
26. CRU is requested to provide detailed cost data on SURGE and data on outputs/results, if the latter is available.
27. Should the CO feel that a brief visit to any project location would be helpful, this will need to be arranged by the former during 26-30 September. All logistical arrangements for such visit will need to be made by the CO.

Annex V: Report of the UNDP Nepal Review Exercise – Nepal Post-Earthquake Response Lessons Learned